What Will He Be? / The Town Turns

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CHOSEN: THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

SCENE 9 — “WHAT WILL HE BE?” / THE TOWN TURNS

CONTINUOUS FROM SCENE 8

No traditional blackout.

Mary and Joseph are walking home together.

The familiar sound of Nazareth begins before the marketplace is fully visible.

HAMMER. BASKET. FABRIC SNAP. CLAP.

The same work vocabulary from Scene 1.

The same stalls. The same baskets. The same fabric. The same people.

For a breath, it feels like home.

Mary and Joseph enter at the edge of the marketplace, still holding hands.

One villager notices.

Then another.

A conversation slows.

A woman stops folding fabric.

A merchant looks up.

No one has become a villain. They simply know—or think they know.

Mary feels the change in the room before anyone says anything.

Her hand tightens around Joseph’s.

Joseph answers with his own.

They keep walking.

THE CHILDREN BREAK THE TENSION

NIA

Mary!

Nia runs toward her before an adult can stop her.

Simon follows, more cautiously. Several children trail behind.

VILLAGER WOMAN 1
Nia—

Too late.

NIA
You’re back!

MARY
I’m back.

Simon looks at Mary. Then Joseph. Then Mary again.

SIMON
Is it true?

VILLAGER WOMAN 2
Simon!

SIMON
What?

NIA
You cannot just ask people things like that.

SIMON
You were going to ask.

NIA
I was going to ask better.

Mary cannot help a small laugh.

MARY
It’s all right.

NIA
Are you really having a baby?

Mary looks briefly at Joseph, then back to the children.

MARY
Yes.

The children light up immediately.

No scandal. No hesitation. Just a baby.

CHILD 1
A boy or a girl?

MARY
A boy.

CHILD 2
When is he coming?

SIMON
Babies do not tell you that.

NIA
How do you know?

SIMON
Everybody knows that.

NIA
You didn’t even know where babies—

SIMON
Nia!

A few adults react. Mary covers another laugh. Joseph does too.

CHILD 3
What will he be like?

Mary pauses.

MARY
I don’t know.

CHILD 3
You don’t?

MARY
Not yet.

SIMON
Will he be loud?

NIA
All babies are loud.

CHILD 1
Maybe he’ll like stories.

CHILD 2
Maybe he’ll build things.

The child looks toward Joseph.

CHILD 2
Like you.

Joseph is caught off guard—not by the question, but by the future inside it.

JOSEPH
Maybe.

CHILD 3
Will you teach him?

Joseph looks at Mary.

This time he does not avoid the answer.

JOSEPH
If he wants to learn, I’ll teach him.

SIMON
What if he’s terrible at it?

JOSEPH
Then I’ll teach him twice.

The children laugh.

A light musical pulse begins.

NIA
What do you think he’ll be?

“WHAT WILL HE BE?” BEGINS

“WHAT WILL HE BE?” — MUSICAL TERRITORY

The children lead. Warm, playful, imaginative. The number is entirely about possibility.

The adults remain in the marketplace, some working, some watching, some whispering.

The song must not explain who Jesus becomes. The audience supplies that knowledge.

LYRICAL TERRITORY — NOT FINAL LYRICS

INTRO

CHILD 3
Will he laugh too loud? / Will he sleep all day?

CHILD 1
Will he race through every market stall / and leave his things in everybody’s way?

CHILD 2
Will he love stories?

SIMON
Will he climb trees?

NIA
Will he ask a hundred questions / before anyone can breathe?

CHORUS 1

What will he be? What will he be?

When he is born, for all to see?

Will he be different or the same?

Will the whole world know his name?

What will he be? What will he be?

The children imagine ordinary futures: animals, stories, running, helping, learning, teaching, courage, kindness.

VERSE 1

CHILD 2
Will he build things out of wood?

JOSEPH
Maybe.

CHILD 3
Make a chair that’s strong and good?

JOSEPH
I hope.

CHILD 1
Will you teach him everything?

Joseph looks at the child, then at Mary.

JOSEPH
Everything I know.

CHILD 1
That’s Good!

CHILDREN
Will he like to run and play?

Help a friend along the way?

Will he dance and flip about?

Will he laugh and scream and shout?

CHORUS 2 (Part 1)

What will he be? What will he be?

When he is born, for all to see?

Will he be different or the same?

Will the whole world know his name?

What will he be? What will he be?

CHORUS 2 (Part 2)

CHILDREN
What will he be?

GOSSIPER 1
Whose child is it?

CHILDREN
What will he be?

VILLAGER WOMAN 1
Before the wedding.

CHILDREN
When he is born, for all to see?

GOSSIPER 2
Does Joseph know?

CHILDREN
Will he be different or the same?

Will the whole world know his name?

What will he be?

GOSSIPER 4
Of course, he knows.

CHILDREN
What will he be?

Dance Break: Children Dance

CHORUS 3

CHILDREN
What will he be?

GOSSIPER 3
Then why is he still with her?

CHILDREN
What will he be?

VILLAGER WOMAN 2
She says there was an angel.

CHILDREN
When he is born, for all to see?

GOSSIPER 4
An Angel?!

CHILDREN
Will he be different or the same?

Will the whole world know his name?

What will he be?

GOSSIPER 3
That’s what I heard.

Villager 3 looks toward Mary.

CHILDREN
What will he be?

GOSSIPER 4
Ay Dios Mio! (eye roll)

SONG ENDS

The children finish joyfully.

CHILDREN
What will he be? (all together, kids laughing)

A brief release—then an adult voice.

VILLAGER WOMAN 1
Nia. Come here!

NIA
But—

VILLAGER WOMAN 1
Now.

Another adult calls a child away.

CHILD 2
Why?

VILLAGER WOMAN 2
Come along.

One by one, the children are removed from Mary's orbit.

Mary watches a child who was laughing beside her moments ago get pulled away.

That hurts more than an insult.

SIMON
What happened?

No adult answers him.

THE GOSSIP RHYTHM RETURNS

A restrained fragment of "Welcome to Nazareth" lives underneath the dialogue, not celebratory now, but tight and repetitive.

GOSSIPER 1
Before the wedding—

GOSSIPER 2
That's what I heard.

GOSSIPER 3
Joseph knows.

GOSSIPER 4
Ay, everybody knows Joseph knows.

GOSSIPER 1
Then why—

GOSSIPER 2
Don’t ask me.

GOSSIPER 4
They say she claims—

GOSSIPER 3
God.

A few villagers react.

GOSSIPER 2
God?

GOSSIPER 1
That’s what she said.

GOSSIPER 4
Convenient.

In Scene 1, everybody knowing everybody was comedy.

Now everybody thinks they know enough.

MARY’S FRIENDS

Shira moves to Mary immediately.

SHIRA
You all right?

MARY
Yes.

She is not completely all right.

SHIRA
All right.

Shira stays.

Adina joins them, scanning the marketplace.

ADINA
This is getting worse.

DAFNA
That is not helpful.

ADINA
I’m not trying to be helpful. I’m trying to be accurate.

DAFNA
That’s Talia’s job.

Talia arrives.

TALIA
What is my job?

DAFNA
Being accurate.

TALIA
Then Adina is correct.

Dafna stares at her.

DAFNA
Nobody here understands comfort.

A small breath of humor. Then—

VILLAGER WOMAN 2
You believe her?

The question is aimed at Talia.

Talia does not pretend certainty she does not have.

TALIA
I believe Mary told us what happened to her.

VILLAGER WOMAN 2
That is not what I asked.

TALIA
I know.

VILLAGER WOMAN 2
So you don’t believe it either.

TALIA
I didn’t say that.

VILLAGER WOMAN 2
Then what are you saying?

Talia steps slightly closer to Mary.

TALIA
I’m saying you weren’t there.

VILLAGER WOMAN 2
Neither were you.

Talia takes the point.

TALIA
No.

Beat.

TALIA
Which means neither of us gets to humiliate her over something we did not see.

Mary looks at her.

Talia gives the smallest nod.

She stays.

JOSEPH'S FRIENDS

Levi, Malachi, Caleb, and Ezra enter or emerge from the marketplace.

They see the crowd. Then Joseph. Then Mary holding Joseph's hand.

Levi stops.

LEVI
You're really doing this.

JOSEPH
Yes.

LEVI
After everything you told us?

JOSEPH
Yes.

LEVI
You believe her?

JOSEPH
I do.

Levi lowers his voice.

LEVI
Then help me understand.

JOSEPH
I can't.

Levi did not expect that.

JOSEPH
Not all of it.

Beat.

JOSEPH
But I know enough to know she told me the truth.

LEVI
I’m trying to protect you.

JOSEPH
I know.

LEVI
Then let me.

JOSEPH
This is me telling you what I chose.

Levi does not like it. But he hears him.

CALEB
You sure?

JOSEPH
I am.

Caleb nods and moves to Joseph’s side.

EZRA
There are still several things about this that make absolutely no sense.

CALEB
Ezra.

EZRA
There are.

JOSEPH
I know.

EZRA
And you’re comfortable with that?

Joseph almost smiles at the absurdity.

JOSEPH
No.

Ezra did not expect that either.

JOSEPH
But understanding everything and knowing what I need to do are not always the same thing.

Ezra considers it.

MALACHI
That’s enough for today.

Malachi stands beside Joseph.

Ezra hesitates, then joins them.

Levi remains slightly apart.

THE PUBLIC TEST

A Villager Man steps forward. Not a villain. A neighbor who believes he is saying the obvious thing.

VILLAGER MAN
Joseph. You don’t have to do this.

JOSEPH
Do what?

VILLAGER MAN
Carry another man’s shame.

The marketplace quiets.

Mary stiffens.

Joseph remains controlled.

JOSEPH
You don’t know what you’re talking about.

VILLAGER MAN
Everybody knows what happened.

JOSEPH
No.

Beat.

JOSEPH
Everybody knows what they heard.

The Villager Man looks at him.

VILLAGER MAN
And you’re willing to throw away your name for this?

Levi reacts to the language.

Joseph sees it.

JOSEPH
My name isn’t worth much if I have to destroy hers to protect it.

Silence.

The Villager Man turns toward Mary.

VILLAGER MAN
Is what they’re saying true?

Joseph does not step in front of Mary.

Mary steps forward herself.

MARY
I told the truth.

VILLAGER MAN
About an angel?

MARY
Yes.

Some villagers stare. A few whisper. One or two may laugh under their breath.

VILLAGER WOMAN 2
And you expect all of us to believe that?

Mary looks around at people she has known all her life.

MARY
No.

That surprises them.

MARY
I can’t make you believe me.

Beat.

MARY
But I will not call what happened to me a lie just to make you comfortable.

Silence.

This is Mary’s public choice.

JOSEPH TRIES TO FIX IT

The whispers restart.

GOSSIPER 2
Did you hear—

GOSSIPER 3
She admitted—

GOSSIPER 4
Joseph actually—

JOSEPH
Enough!

Mary gently touches his arm.

MARY
Joseph.

JOSEPH
They’re talking about you.

MARY
I know.

JOSEPH
I can explain—

MARY
To all of them?

Joseph looks around.

Every face has an opinion.

MARY
You don’t have to answer everyone.

JOSEPH
I want to.

MARY
I know.

Beat.

MARY
But you can’t build your way out of this.

It lands without cruelty.

Joseph looks at the village.

For once, he lets the problem remain unsolved.

NIA AND SIMON

Nia and Simon have watched all of this from nearby.

NIA
Why is everybody angry?

No one answers.

SIMON
It’s still a baby.

The simple line hangs there.

NIA
We were just singing.

An adult calls.

VILLAGER WOMAN 1
Nia.

Nia does not move immediately.

VILLAGER WOMAN 1
Come.

Nia looks at Mary.

Mary gives her a small reassuring smile.

Nia goes.

Simon follows, looking back once.

THE SAME TOWN — DIVIDED

The ensemble reorganizes without becoming a cartoon of good people and bad people.

Near Mary and Joseph: Shira, Adina, Dafna, Talia, Caleb, Malachi, and Ezra.

At a distance: skeptical villagers, whisperers, people who simply do not know what to think.

Levi remains between the two groups.

Nobody wins the argument.

Nazareth does not apologize.

The gossip rhythm begins to peak.

GOSSIPER 1
Joseph knows—

GOSSIPER 2
Before the wedding—

GOSSIPER 3
An angel—

GOSSIPER 4
A child—

GOSSIPER 1
God—

GOSSIPER 3
Can you believe—

GOSSIPER 4
Everybody knows—

BOOM.

A Roman drum cuts through the marketplace.

Everything stops.

BOOM.

A trumpet or unmistakable imperial sound.

Rome does not care about Nazareth’s scandal.

ROME ENTERS

The Roman Announcer enters as though his arrival is unquestionably the most important event of the day.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
People of Nazareth!

A few villagers are still murmuring.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
People.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
Of.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
Nazareth.

The village quiets.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
Thank you.

He unrolls the decree.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
By decree of Caesar Augustus—

A villager groans.

The Announcer stops and looks directly at them.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
Your enthusiasm is noted.

CALEB
We haven’t even heard it yet.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
And still you’ve disappointed Rome.

A few villagers react.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
A census shall be taken. Every household is to be registered according to family line and ancestral city.

Immediate murmuring.

TALIA
We have to travel?

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
If your ancestral city is elsewhere, yes.

LEVI
Who pays for the journey?

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
Excellent question.

Beat.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
You do.

The village groans.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
You will present yourself, your household, and the required family information in the appropriate city.

VILLAGER
When?

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
Immediately.

CALEB
Immediately?

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
Immediately! It is a wonderful word.

Beat.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
It means now.

The marketplace explodes into practical anxiety: counting, packing, questions, arguments.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
Govern yourselves accordingly.

He begins to roll the decree.

ROMAN ANNOUNCER
Thank yooou.

He exits as the Roman drum resumes.

BETHLEHEM

The marketplace is now moving for an entirely different reason.

Mary looks at Joseph.

He is doing the calculation before she asks.

MARY
Joseph?

Beat.

JOSEPH
Bethlehem.

Mary knows what that means: distance, travel, timing.

MARY
When do we leave?

Joseph looks at her.

His first instinct is to protect her.

JOSEPH
Mary—

MARY
When?

He sees that she is not asking whether she is going.

She has already decided that.

Joseph exhales.

JOSEPH
As soon as we can.

Mary nods.

Their hands find each other again.

Around them, Nazareth prepares to move.

Shira offers to help Mary prepare for the journey. Mary squeezes Joseph's hand, then follows Shira along the lit side lane to change. Joseph remains in the marketplace.

END SCENE 9